

Thesis: AI agents will become first-class economic actors—searching, negotiating, paying, getting paid and reconciling on behalf of people and businesses. To enable this shift, a new layer of agent-native financial infrastructure (“AFI”) must be built: identity, authorization, payment protocols, controls and accounting designed for software that transacts at machine speed rather than for a human clicking “buy.”

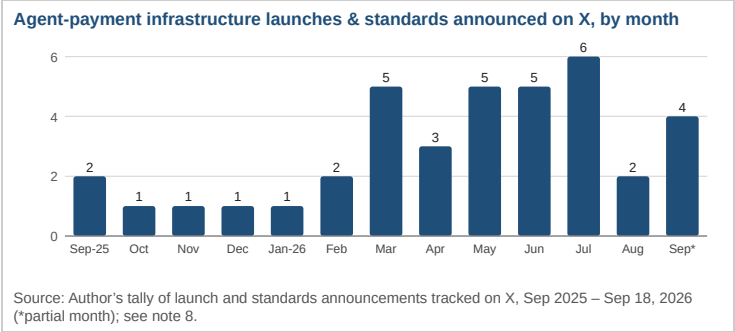
Overview: In twelve months on X, agent payments went from demo to category. Every major network shipped a standard: Google’s Agent Payments Protocol (Sep 2025), Stripe and OpenAI’s Agentic Commerce Protocol (Sep 2025), Visa’s Trusted Agent Protocol (Oct 2025), Shopify and Google’s Universal Commerce Protocol (Jan 2026), Stripe and Tempo’s Machine Payments Protocol (Mar 2026) and Mastercard’s Agent Pay for Machines (Jun 2026). In July 2026 the x402 protocol moved under the Linux Foundation with 40 members, including Visa, Mastercard, Stripe, Amex, Google and AWS. Demand signals are real but uneven: Alipay’s AI Pay cleared 120M agent transactions in a single week, onchain agents settled \$73M across 176M transactions in twelve months, and McKinsey expects agents to mediate \$3–5T of commerce by 2030.^{2,7}

Tailwinds for Agent Infrastructure: The build-out has staying power and significant growth potential because^{1,2,3,4}:

- Every network now has an agent protocol
 - Micropayment economics break card fee floors
 - Regulators are engaging rather than blocking
- Stablecoins enable 24/7, machine-speed settlement
 - Merchants are asking “how,” not “if”
 - Finance teams want autonomous back offices

The Role of AFI: Version one of agentic commerce—the store inside the chatbot—failed fast. OpenAI pulled Instant Checkout within months of launch after users browsed but rarely bought; Walmart reported conversion roughly three times lower than on its own site and moved its Sparky agent into ChatGPT and Gemini instead. Simon Taylor’s read spread widely: “The AI does not own the checkout. The merchant does.” Version two puts the agent inside the store: Anthropic’s open-source Claude Commerce Agents (Sep 2026, with Visa and Mastercard “day one” and a Shopify reference implementation) report carts up to 35% larger, and Adyen Agentic sells itself as a “universal translator” that keeps the merchant as merchant of record.

Meanwhile the plumbing has run ahead of demand. x402’s daily settlement volume fell 93% from roughly \$800K in January to \$40K in September, with much of the December 2025 peak later judged synthetic⁵—yet Verda Ventures counts 950 agentic-payments startups, 377 founded in 2026 and 88% at pre-seed or seed.⁶ As in the first wave of vertical SaaS, I believe the winners will be firms that attach infrastructure to real, recurring machine spend (API calls, compute, data, B2B bill pay) rather than to speculative consumer checkout, and that make the four hard things—identity, authorization, settlement and audit—boring for everyone else.



Market Map

Identity & Trust Visa TAP · Mastercard credentialing · Google AP2 VDCs · ERC-8004 · Ant/Visa/MC KYA framework · Billions · Kite AI	Authorization & Controls Ramp Agent Cards · Coinbase Agentic Wallets · Fireblocks · Alchemy AgentCard · Natural	Protocols & Orchestration ACP (Stripe/OpenAI) · UCP (Shopify/Google) · AP2 · MPP (Stripe/Tempo) · x402 Foundation · Adyen Agentic · Stripe Agentic Commerce Suite	Settlement Rails Mastercard AP4M · Visa Intelligent Commerce Connect · USDC on Base · Tempo · Ripple RLUSD · Alipay AI Pay
Merchant-Side Agents Claude Commerce Agents · Shopify · Walmart Sparky · Nuvei · Adyen	Banking & Treasury Fiserv agentOS · Backbone · Anchorage/Google Cloud · ClawBank · Airwallex · Visa+Ramp bill pay · Entendre	Data & Connectivity Plaid · ChatGPT Finance · Grok · MCP servers (Visa, Coinbase, Alipay)	Risk, Disputes & Compliance EPAA/HSBC working group · Bank of England · Dispute automation · Policy engines / audit trails

I believe that firms will build solutions that address the concepts and trends shown below:

- **“Know Your Agent” becomes the KYC of the agent economy**
KYC verifies the human; the agent acting for them has no identity, no history and no way to prove its mandate. On X this gap now has a name—KYA—and every layer is racing to fill it: Visa’s Trusted Agent Protocol gives vetted agents a cryptographic signature, Mastercard’s Agent Pay for Machines adds agent credentialing, Google’s AP2 uses verifiable digital credentials to trace intent to settlement, and ERC-8004 adds identity, reputation and validation registries onchain.
In September, Ant International, Visa and Mastercard announced a KYA interoperability framework, and 176 of the 950 agentic-payments startups Verda tracks work on identity and authorization alone.⁶ A portable credential bundling who deployed the agent, what it may spend and how to revoke it will be as foundational as the card token.
- **Delegated spend with programmable guardrails**
The breakout product of 2026 was not a wallet but a card: Ramp Agent Cards (Mar 2026) gave agents “real spend limits, merchant controls, and full visibility into every transaction.” Coinbase Agentic Wallets, Fireblocks’ Agentic Payments Suite (scoped permissions and revocable access enforced by its policy engine), Alchemy’s AgentCard on Visa and Google AP2’s “begin by setting strict guardrails” all converge on one primitive: delegated, capped, auditable authority.
The control plane—limits, counterparty allowlists, approval thresholds, emergency revocation—is the product; the rail underneath is interchangeable. Cards are the bridge that works today; crypto-native builders argue they are “a workaround” until programmable rails mature.
- **Protocol sprawl creates a market for orchestration**
ACP, UCP, AP2, MPP, TAP, x402 and Alipay’s AHA all launched within a year, prompting the obvious question on X: “Who wins this?” Likely none alone. The x402 Foundation now counts Visa, Mastercard, Stripe, Amex, Google, AWS and Adyen as members, Stripe’s Agentic Commerce Suite supports both ACP and UCP, and Adyen explicitly sells itself as a “universal translator.”
Just as payment orchestration emerged when PSPs proliferated, an agent-payments orchestration layer—routing a mandate to whichever protocol and rail the counterparty accepts—will be a durable business.
- **Merchant-side agents, not chatbot checkout**
Users research in the chatbot and buy in the store. PayPal’s Pulse report says merchants are past “if” and onto “how.”³ Claude Commerce Agents and Shopify’s same-day reference implementation show the shape: a shopping agent embedded in the merchant’s site plus a merchant agent managing inventory and returns.
Infrastructure that makes existing catalogs, carts, tax and fulfillment agent-readable (Adyen’s Feed/Cart/Payments stack, Visa Intelligent Commerce Connect) while leaving the merchant in control of price and customer will win spend; intermediaries that own the checkout and take a cut will not.
- **Stablecoin micro-rails for machine-to-machine spend**
x402 and MPP turn HTTP 402 “Payment Required” into live pay-per-call: Browserbase charges agents per browser session, AWS-hosted agents pay for services in USDC on Base, and Tempo settles MPP in USDC or cards via Stripe. With 76% of agent transactions below Visa’s \$0.30 fee floor and an average ticket near \$0.48, cards cannot serve this traffic.²
The reality check is volume: real x402 transactions peaked at 1.43M/day in December 2025 and fell to 180K/day by February, and the rail is described as one whose “demand is just not there yet.” The opportunity is real but API-first and B2B; consumer agent payments will arrive last.
- **Agent-native banking and treasury**
Banks and core providers are building the operating-system layer: Fiserv agentOS (six institutions piloting, with OpenAI and AWS), Backbone’s AI-native banking OS, Anchorage Digital and Google Cloud’s regulated “Agentic Banking” that enforces corporate spend policy and KYA before settlement, and ClawBank’s FDIC-insured virtual accounts for “zero-human companies.”
On the corporate side, Airwallex says agents will automate 70%+ of finance-team work, Visa and Ramp shipped bill-pay agents, and Entendre and Oracle target close, reconciliation and treasury. Expect agent-to-agent AP/AR: one agent pays an invoice, another reconciles it.
- **The data-access fight repeats open banking**
ChatGPT Finance (via Plaid) and Grok now read users’ bank, card and brokerage data; Plaid built its own foundation model and shipped tokenization to make statements agent-readable. Matt Janiga’s warning resonated: banks now have far better tooling to block “unwanted traffic” than in the screen-scraping era.
The likely resolution is permissioned agent APIs and MCP servers—Visa, Coinbase and Alipay already expose them—turning agent data access into a licensed, metered infrastructure business.
- **Liability, disputes and regulation move from theory to working groups**
The Emerging Payments Association Asia and HSBC formed the region’s first agentic-payments working group covering identity, liability, fraud and disputes; the Bank of England’s Sarah Breedon said existing frameworks “were not built to contemplate autonomous agents” and a human in the loop for every action “is unlikely to be realistic.”⁴
25% of executives cite user distrust as the blocker. Tooling that produces an audit trail from user intent to settlement, automates disputes (one team took win rates from 0% to 78% in a month) and underwrites agent risk will be demanded by every counterparty.

1. Payments Outlook: Five Shifts Powering Payments in 2026 (J.P. Morgan Payments) 2. State of Agents 2026 / Keyrock: 76% of agent transactions fall below Visa’s \$0.30 fee floor; \$73M across 176M transactions, 98.6% USDC 3. Agentic Commerce Pulse Report (May 2026, PayPal) 4. Deputy Governor Sarah Breedon speech on agentic AI (Jul 2026, Bank of England, via @samboboev) 5. Agentic payment rail shows volume decline (Sep 2026, American Banker); x402 data via @FourPillarsFP 6. Stablescape stablecoin market map, 6,128 companies (Aug 2026, Verda Ventures) 7. McKinsey agentic-commerce estimate via @rohanpaul_ai (Mar 2026); @Alipay (Feb 13, 2026) 8. Selected X posts, Sep 2025–Sep 2026: @GoogleCloudTech, @stripe, @patrickc, @jackforestell, @Mastercard, @CoinbaseDev, @RampLabs, @FireblocksHQ, @base, @syttaylor, @ClaudeDevs, @Shopify, @Alipay, @Ant_Intl, @sygnumofficial, @regulatorynerd, @twintitech, @naturalpay, @eric_seufert, @pareekhjain, @Fiserv, @samboboev (full list in sources.md).